

# PRESERVING A LEGACY

Thanks to the efforts of conservator Vijaynath Shenoy and the Royal Netherlands Embassy, the legacy of Raja Ravi Varma, arguably India's biggest name in art, will finally find a permanent museum



■ By Nirmala Ravindran

For over 150 years there has been no artist who can claim to have captured the imagination of India like Raja Ravi Varma; for Indians, even today, recognise Hindu gods and goddesses depending on how Ravi Varma painted them. His images adorned everything—from matchbox labels to Diwali crackers to commercial advertisements. A pioneer, his canvases were and are still sought-after by collectors from across the world. But

strangely Ravi Varma's fame did not come from his original works, though they are acknowledged masterpieces; on the contrary, he became a household name thanks to his press. His images adorned so many calendars that some art historians dismissed him as a calendar artist in the late 18th century only to take back their words later. From calendars as decoration, to galleries as art and to puja rooms to be worshipped—Ravi Varma's story is all about the pioneering printing press and the legacy of popular images. It is this legacy that conservator Vijaynath Shenoy of the Hasta Shilpa Trust seeks to immortalise at the Archive of Raja Ravi Varma Press being set up in Manipal, near Mangalore.

For many, in the art community, both in India and abroad, the disbelief that a Raja Ravi Varma

museum does not already exist comes as a shock. "I know there are trusts in both Germany and Italy that have been working towards the creation of a Ravi Varma museum. I cannot, however, believe that the government of India or the governments of Maharashtra or Kerala (the two states he was connected to, the first by birth and the other by choosing to live there) have not created museums in his memory or restored his collection of art work," says German art historian Peter Bertram, a scholar who was involved with research on the artist's works. Ravi Varma's work was deeply influenced by the West, especially Germany. All his art material was imported from Germany, he was deeply influenced by the colours and styles of western art that he incorporated into his own work, giving Hindu mythology a western touch in terms of styling and colours. Just before his death, Ravi Varma sold the press to his German technician Fritz Schleicher, who was responsible for the multitude of prints that were produced at the press. It is

**HERITAGE VALUE:**  
(Top) Raja Ravi Varma and litho stones (right); a collection of oleographs (left)

